

ST. MATTHEW PASSION

In the St. Matthew Passion, sung in German and shown here in a handwritten score from the 1740s, Bach's music stresses the terrible anguish of the Crucifixion.

Travels and troubles

Bach did not follow musical fashions. In 1737, he was strongly attacked by the young music critic Johann Adolf Scheibe for his allegedly “bombastic and confused style” that offended contemporary tastes for simplicity and clarity of melody and harmony. However, Bach's later music only served to reaffirm his old-fashioned commitment to dense counterpoint, or the intertwining of two or more melodic lines.

In 1747, on a visit to Berlin, he was invited to play in front of the Prussian king, Frederick the Great, who was employing Bach's son Carl Philipp Emmanuel (see [box](#)) as a court musician. The king presented Bach with an original theme on which—for the royal amusement—he spontaneously improvised a three-part fugue at the pianoforte. Back in Leipzig, he used the same theme to create *The Musical Offering*, a set of contrapuntal pieces including a six-part fugue. Up to his death, he was working on his *Art of Fugue*, an exhaustive exploration of the possibilities of contrapuntal writing that was a monumental tribute to a disappearing musical world.